

A Family Found

A Collection of Short Stories

By Evan Atkins

Finding Your Footing

Dice settles back into the plush green bean bag in the small studio apartment. She can't recall a time when one of Aunt Maya's spaces didn't carry her warmth and welcome. Sure, Aunt Maya's apartment is as messy, colorful, and slightly overstimulating as she is, but Dice wouldn't have it any other way. It's better than the too-sleek, too-clean penthouse she lives in with her mother. The contrast between the severely artistic, open-concept apartment and her mother Cala's white, minimalist, near-brutalist penthouse is almost painful to exist in. Dice has done it her entire life, though, finding comfort in the contrast between the wildly different sisters now more so than when she was a child.

The cybernetic fingers of her right hand flex before slowly beginning to tap the atomic numbers of the elements in her titanium alloy that has replaced many of her bones.

"Worried about something?" Maya's voice cuts off her spiral before it starts.

Dice's hand freezes on the bean bag, then she smiles slightly, awkwardly. "Uh... Yeah, a little."

Maya nods, putting down the cup of tea on the side table between them. "What's going on, Di?" She asks softly, settling into her hanging chair, which she has woven herself.

As the question settles on her, Dice sighs and rubs her face. She reaches for the tea, looking into the deep amber color, trying to guess what kind it is. "Just... I... I got accepted into grad school."

Maya nods, taking her cup. "I know. Just like I know you like jasmine black tea with one small scoop of sugar."

The way her aunt reads her so well makes Dice smile a little wider. Some of her anxiety dissolves, even as the right side of her face twitches and refuses to smile fully. Even though she

has come to terms with her cybernetic body after the autopod accident, she is still occasionally frustrated when her right half refuses to listen to her brain. “Thanks, Auntie.”

“Always, Di.” Maya smiles back, her eyes crinkling in endearment at her struggling right half. “Now, talk to me, nibbling.”

Dice takes a slow sip of her tea. Perfect, as ever with her aunt. “... I think I’m ready to move out.”

Maya pauses, then nods, taking a sip of her own tea, probably milk tea based on the color. “I see.” She tries not to be too visibly excited, but Dice can see it in the way Maya’s eyes shine and momentarily slide away from hers. “That sounds good. Do you need any help?”

“I don’t know,” Dice takes a slow breath. “I want to try myself first.”

“Alright,” Maya nods, smiling encouragingly. “I’m here if you need me.”

“I know. Thank you.” Dice smiles at Maya, small and less inhibited this time. “I think I’ll look closer to NekoTech U, then look further out from there.”

Maya nods, taking a slow sip of her tea. “Good plan. Just be ready for rent to be—”

“The higher, the closer to campus it is. I know.”

“Because—”

“Because the university owns it and they’d rather you live on campus than off.”

“Mhmm.” Maya sighs softly.

“Sorry,” Dice mumbles into her tea. She knows how often her mother cuts off Maya.

Dice does her best not to perpetuate it, but sometimes she can’t help it.

“You’re nervous,” Maya says softly. “You’ve done a lot of research, you’re telling me first, and you are being fully independent.”

Dice frowns. Sometimes she wishes her aunt were less observant. Or less emotionally intelligent. Granted, her aunt is the only reason she has any emotional inclination. Cala Calen isn't exactly known for her emotional ability or general affect. Dice has done her best not to follow her mother's footsteps, but she has had limited success.

She has learned in more recent years how her childhood put further strain on her aunt's and mother's relationship. Neither could agree on how to raise Dice, leading to an argument because both were afraid Dice would turn out horribly or suffer in her childhood. Then the accident. The cybernetics. The hospitals. The never-ending flow of doctors, of poking and prodding, and of going from a normal 10-year-old to a cybernetic scientist's favorite lab rat overnight. It changed everything, and Dice wouldn't say it was for the better.

"Dice," Maya calls, leaning closer, "no spiraling. What's bothering you?"

The direct call, pulling Dice from her thoughts more gently than how Cala ever breaks up Dice's temporary dissociation, pulls a sigh from her. "I don't... I have to tell Mom."

"You do," Maya says, setting her cup down and reaching over to rest a hand on Dice's arm. "But you don't have to do it alone."

Dice looks down at her hand, momentarily taken off guard by the gentle comfort, then leans into it and nods. "I know," she breathes. "I know, but it is still so— so..."

"Scary?" Maya offers.

A mute nod is all Dice can give. The idea of confronting her mother, of telling Dr. Cala Calen that she is leaving, terrifies her. The overt hovering, the invasive parenting, the near-suffocating monitoring of her cybernetics, the lack of socializing because her mother keeps her home, keeps her safe...

"I can't do it anymore," Dice mumbles, staring at the space between her and Maya.

Maya frowns, not in pity, but in self-recrimination. “You don’t have to,” she says softly, refusing to focus on herself in this moment.

“But—”

“No.” The word comes out firmer than Dice is used to hearing from Maya. “You do not have to stay anywhere that exhausts you. You can love your mother and keep a distance. You can appreciate that she cares, and protect yourself from her grief and guilt.”

“Auntie,” Dice mumbles, looking up at her aunt with a distress more visible than she would ever let show anywhere else.

“I know,” Maya sighs, reaching out to take Dice’s trembling cup and put it to the side. “You deserved better, deserved to be a kid, regardless of the accident. And neither of us gave that to you, for which I am sorry.” She says more softly, moving from her chair to the floor beside Dice. She reaches up to gently hold and caress Dice’s face. “We cannot change the past, but we can guide the future. You don’t have to do anything yet. Right now, you can just be.” Maya’s voice gets softer as Dice shakes a little more.

Dice leans down, resting her head on Maya’s shoulder as tears begin to well in her left eye. She grips Maya’s arms as Maya pulls her into a deep, warm embrace. Frustration grips Dice at the lack of reaction from her right side. Why couldn’t she have been normal? Why does she have to be broken?

“Di,” Maya murmurs into Dice’s dark hair, “stay with me.” Maya rocks her slowly, petting her hair and breathing fully, deeply, silently, trying to encourage Dice to copy her.

Neither moves for several minutes. It feels like hours to Dice, but barely half an hour passes in the time it takes for her to cry her emotions out.

Maya has always been the only one Dice can genuinely cry with. Cala will tell her not to waste her limited energy on such emotional displays. There is never a teacher she feels safe and comfortable with, not even other cyborg teachers.

The chances of being in an autopod accident are practically one in a million anymore. Even another cyborg couldn't understand the trauma. Even other cyborgs don't have as extensive internal damage as Dice. Replacing entire organs, rebuilding nerves to even half their previous ability, and maintaining titanium limbs on the right half of a whole body, there are only 16 others on the planet with damage as intense or worse than hers. Most damage can be fully rectified, or at least the quality of life can be more fully restored.

Instead, Dice is left with a just functional enough right half that only slightly meshes with her left half, and a mother who buries her in guilt parenting because it happens to be her autopod.

Still, Dice knows she cannot remain here, in Maya's arms, forever. "Auntie," she starts, her voice hoarse. "Can I stay for dinner?" It is barely two in the afternoon.

"Of course, Di," Maya says softly. "You can stay as long as you like."

~~~~~

In the two weeks that follow, Dice tries everything she can think of to find an apartment. She starts with the university housing site, then extends to a 5-kilometer radius around campus. She looks at quite a few places, but most are relatively expensive, given that most off-campus housing is owned by NekoTech anyway, and they price it high enough to make dormitories look reasonable by comparison.

However, the few times she finds something close enough for the Line to get her to campus at a reasonable price, the rent isn't sky-high, there are still myriad issues. Almost every apartment, even NekoTech-owned, isn't designed with cybernetic accessibility in mind, what

with poor electrical systems for charging stations, electromagnetic interference issues, or facilities that can't handle the maintenance requirements of mechanical limbs.

Then, on the handful of occasions that she finds reasonable prices and sturdy, generally accessible buildings, she faces discrimination. Four landlords give some excuse for not renting to a cyborg. It's insurance, building regulations, general infrastructure, students generally being bad tenants, or any other reason under the sun.

She knows it will be hard and that she will face scrutiny, but this is beyond her wildest expectations. This leaves Dice with little choice but to return to her aunt and ask for help. Unlike with her mother, she isn't wary of asking for help.

She still distinctly remembers being eight and in the early stages of her education, struggling with her multiplication tables. She was already the youngest in her class, having been moved ahead in math and science given her gifted ability with numbers, but memorization wasn't easy. When she asked her mother for help, Cala was stiff, then simply forced Dice to go through every virtual flash card. Every time she got it wrong, her mother did not yell or reprimand her, though Dice almost wishes her mother had been more tangible in her cruelty. Instead, she made a disapproving face and demanded, "Again." It took all night, and the next day was more complicated, not easier. She learned her multiplication tables, but she never came to her mother for help again. Not when her history classes were more challenging, not even when her education changed so drastically barely two years later.

She remembers resenting her reliance on Cala as a kid and even as a teen. Now, at 22, she feels more independent, knows her body better, and can do basic maintenance on her own. She still avoids leaning on her mother, but now that she isn't entirely dependent on Cala, getting ready to be fully independent no less, she feels more settled and less resentful.

Dice appreciates the warm creaks of the synthetic-wood stairs up to her aunt's apartment, over the echoey clacking of shoes on marble in the penthouse. She has done her best to organize her search around her mother's schedule. She can't face her mother alone, not about this.

The chime on her aunt's door is a custom twinkle, made by one of her art classes a few years ago: a melodic sound made of specific radio frequencies.

It barely takes a minute for Maya to answer with a warm, gentle smile. "I made some tea," she holds up the thermos as proof, giving it a little shake before handing Dice the black-and-blue curve-striped thermos. "It'll help keep us going through our apartment hunting. Are you ready?"

Dice blinks, taking the hand-painted thermos. It is hard to forget the painting class where, while she made excellent curved lines, she went through 16 cylinders and got paint in one of her joints. What a mess that had been, but it still makes her smile.

But her smile fades fairly quickly as she processes Maya's words. "As I'll ever be. I just hope today is better. I don't know how much longer I can avoid Mom."

Maya gives an empathetic nod and reaches out to gently squeeze Dice's organic shoulder. "I know. We'll get it done today, promise."

With a big breath, Dice nods. "Alright. Let's get started."

Dice is rightfully nervous, but Maya makes things feel just a little smoother and simpler. They look at new places, apartments Dice hasn't even considered. Some of them are so old that they still have organic wood, a protected material that can't be available for decades. People are nicer to Dice, though. She can't tell whether it's simply because Maya does most of the talking or because of the near-threatening smile her aunt wears when someone seems to take issue with her nibbling's cybernetics.

The buildings Maya finds have Line stops no more than 10 minutes away, and the rides themselves will take no more than 15 minutes, so taking public transit isn't inconvenient. Granted, Dice questions the safety and security of most of the buildings, but Maya just laughs. "Honey, student living is never fair or pretty unless you want to pay more than even I, a full-time instructor, could afford."

While Dice has spent weeks struggling and failing to find anywhere at all that will take her, within four hours of hunting with her aunt, she finds a drab L-shaped building with peeling paint and nearly rusty metal stairs leading up to the second level. Thankfully, Unit 8 is on the ground floor. It's a 3-bedroom apartment. The older woman, with a heavy accent from the northern highlands, who owns the place, says she will only charge for the one bedroom and main space being used, as long as Dice actively looks for roommates and finds one or two within 6-8 months.

Lunta Grey doesn't seem the least bit put off by Dice's cybernetics, nor apologetic about the building's age or wear. Dice, eventually, works up the nerve to ask, "Ms. Grey—"

"Lunta is fine, lass," she interjects.

Dice blinks, but nods. "Lunta," using the woman's first name, feels wrong on her tongue. "Why aren't you—"

"Bothered?" The older woman gives a sly grin and widens her eyes, and the glow around her irises makes Dice freeze.

"You're—"

"Had a defect in the womb," she chuckles, blinking a bit to soothe her cybernetic eyes again. "I've had these since I was a babe. Couldn't tell ya how handy and irritatin' they are. Yer safe 'ere, lass."

The surprise gives way to odd comfort as Dice smiles and looks around the small apartment before settling on Lunta again. “So, I can stay?” She asks, barely a whisper, the space and drab wallpaper suddenly the most exciting thing she’s seen in months.

Lunta and Maya share a look behind Dice, who is too absorbed to notice anything else but what will soon be hers. Lunta raises a brow at the older woman, who is visibly holding Dice together. Maya just gives a slight encouraging grin. Lunta nods, then addresses Dice. “Right, lass, the place can be yours as soon as the paperwork’s done.”

Dice spins in near childlike glee that Maya hasn’t seen in over a decade. “I did it?” She whispers, looking desperately at Maya for confirmation.

Maya smiles warmly. “You did it, Di.”

For the first time since she was able to walk again on her cybernetics, Dice looks like she could launch herself at either woman with joy.

~~~~

The excitement of three days prior, of signing the documents, of beginning the hunt for bargain or free furniture, has long since died as Dice stands in front of the elevator to go up to Cala’s penthouse. Maya is already upstairs. She knows she doesn’t have to do this alone, but that does little to soothe her.

She jumps slightly at the soft beep of the elevator, grimacing at her own reaction. She doesn’t like being this on edge, even if she understands logically why her body is already on alert.

It only takes about 30 seconds to get to the penthouse, but it feels both instantaneous and far too long. The door slides open to the small lobby area. Dice steps forward and presses her organic hand to the small sensor beside the door, not even bothering to check the mail or wipe

her feet as she usually would. The doors slide to either side, and Dice takes one more shaky breath as she steps into the familiar expanse of white marble and stark surfaces. The penthouse's open concept feels more like a medical facility than a home. The house is all clean lines, hidden storage, and surfaces that could be sterilized at a moment's notice.

She hears Maya's soft laughter and smells the familiar, warm, slightly bitey scent of the only dish Cala can make: arrabiata sauce with spicy synthetic sausage over spaghetti noodles. It has been comforting during Dice's healing, as it is the only time she feels her mother is truly calm and her least abrasive.

"You should have seen the look on his face when we played the noise music for him!" Maya is sitting on the counter, swinging her feet, sipping wine as she laughs about more classroom shenanigans.

"I am certain it was amusing, given your clear adoration for this tale," Cala replies stiffly, plainly, standing over the sauce and stirring it carefully. Despite her general lack of visible affect, Dice can tell this is Cala being as accommodating as she can be to Maya's more emotionally inclined side.

"No kidding. I think my director thinks I'm crazy."

"Would he be wrong?"

Maya smiles widely, giving a dramatic gasp, and holds her wine closer. "My big sister? Telling a joke? I never thought I'd see the day."

Cala huffs in amusement, the closest she will ever get to laughing. "Continue to jest at me, and it shall cease immediately."

"As if," Maya scoffs with a grin. "You can't resist my humor, admit it!"

Dice doesn't mean to stumble, doesn't mean to knock the table in the entryway, or fumble to catch Maya's bag before it nearly falls off. The sisterly moment, a kind of camaraderie and companionship Dice rarely gets to see between the two anymore, is over.

Cala is immediately stiff, whipping around to see if Dice is well or further damaged. Maya turns too, but meets Dice with an empathetic gaze, knowing precisely what is not only running through her head, but her body.

"Dice." Cala's voice is firm, cold. "You need to exercise caution when moving through smaller spaces. Are your servos properly calibrated?" She moves, abandoning the pot to begin examining Dice. "Have you experienced an imbalance in movements in the past two weeks? This is what happens when you are not home at regular intervals."

She grabs Dice by the wrist, pulling her into the main area, checking her over, then grabs a scanner to begin assessing her joints and artificial muscles. "You can be a foolish child. You know better than to go more than three days without calibration."

"Mom, I'm fine. Please—" She tries to pull away.

"Do not fight me, Dice." Cala tightens her grip on Dice's upper arm. "You do not ignore any change in motor function. It could be anything."

Dice looks helplessly at Maya, who has jumped off the counter to stir the pot in her sister's stead, wine abandoned on the marble counter beside her. Maya meets her eyes, then takes a deep breath to steel herself.

"Cala," Maya calls. "She's fine. I checked her at my place a couple of days ago. She's just nervous."

"Nervous?" Cala looks quickly from her sister to her child. "Have your grades slipped? Did you lie to me about your acceptance to graduate school?"

Dice tenses and tries to pull away again. “No, no! That’s not— Mom, please. Let go of me.”

Cala opens her mouth to argue, but Maya cuts in from the kitchen. “Gripping too tightly can hurt the artificial muscle strength, no?”

There is a moment of silence, then Cala releases Dice but does not move away. “You are certain her levels were correct? Is her joint balance optimal? The—”

“Yes, Cala. She’s fine. You gonna come stir? I don’t know what it’s supposed to look like, not like you do.”

Cala takes a breath, standing a little taller at the indirect praise. “Indeed. You have rarely been so competent in the kitchen. It is why my mother had me cook most nights in our youth.” She looks Dice up and down once more, then turns to walk to the kitchen, waving a hand for her to follow. Dice follows, dutifully.

Maya sighs, stepping aside as Cala takes over. She looks at Dice, a soft question in her eyes: “You okay?”

Dice gives a barely perceptible nod. Maya tilts her head a little, knowing it is a half-truth at most, but gives a little encouraging smile.

“Is there a reason for this gathering?” Cala asks point-blank, turning to hold Maya’s eyes.

“Can’t we just have a family dinner?” Maya asks, raising a brow at her sister.

“We rarely have group meals without events or purpose.” Cala counters, turning back to the sauce.

“Di got into—”

“Her name is Dice.”

There is a brief pause as Maya takes a quiet breath. “Dice, got into grad school. Isn’t that something worth celebrating?”

“Graduating is an event of celebration. Graduating with a doctorate, specifically, is worth celebrating, as it will signal the end of her academic journey and the beginning of her work with me in Hethan’s Medical sector.”

As Cala talks, Maya rolls her eyes and mouths along in a slightly mocking way, wine glass sloshing as she exaggerates her movements. Dice tries to suppress her smile, covering her mouth, only making Maya grin and mock even more dramatically. Cala pauses, turning to give the two a slight, suspicious look, who quickly, and only partially successfully, try to school their expressions.

“... You are mocking me.”

Maya grins. “What? Me? Mock my amazing big sister? Never.”

Cala sighs, Maya giggles, and Dice smiles softly. She misses easy interaction like this. It hasn’t happened nearly as often since the accident.

“Let’s finish the food, then we can talk about adult stuff, yeah?” Maya offers.

“That is agreeable,” Cala says plainly, giving a slight nod as she returns her full focus to the sauce. “Dice. Go get the spaghetti from the pantry.”

Dice silently does as instructed. Maya watches with a fairly neutral expression, but her eyes track her nibbling.

“In the meantime, you two can be my captive audience as I complain deeply, thoroughly, about the recent educational restructure that has put many students at a disadvantage!” Maya announces her intention as she lifts herself back onto the counter.

Dice sighs, and Cala briefly looks to the ceiling. It is going to be a long night.

~~~~

“Ah, Cala, delicious as ever,” Maya says with a sigh, pushing the plate away and leaning back in her chair, sipping the water she has replaced the now-empty wine glass with. “Thank you,” she adds with a slight smile.

“Thank you, Mom,” Dice says quietly.

Cala nods, dabbing her mouth with her cloth napkin. “Naturally. You are both welcome.”

Maya meets Dice’s eyes, raising a brow. Dice swallows and looks back down at her plate. She hasn’t wanted to eat all of it because she feels nauseous, but she knows Cala will get after her if she doesn’t. She feels overly full, which only makes the coming conversation more overwhelming.

“Now, we are to discuss something of importance?” Cala questions, looking between the two on either side of the small circular table.

“Well, we have something to tell you, but we need something from you while we tell you,” Maya starts, giving Dice a moment to collect herself.

“And that is?” Cala holds her gaze on Dice for several seconds before finally meeting Maya’s.

“We need to be fully heard, without interruption, until we are done. Then we can discuss.” Maya outlines the expectations calmly.

Cala looks unimpressed. “As you wish,” she says flippantly.

Maya looks back at Dice, waiting for her nibbling to be ready. Dice looks up at Maya, then glances at Cala. She regrets it nearly immediately as Cala stares with expectant, already

disappointed expression. But she knows she has little choice. Whether she likes it or not, it is time to put her foot down.

“Mom,” Dice starts, her voice quiet and a touch shaky.

“Speak up, Dice,” Cala corrects coolly.

Dice’s face tightens, a quiet anger stirring in her twisted gut. “... I’m moving out.” She speaks louder, clearer, her face firm and fists clenched in her lap.

There is a tense silence as Dice holds Cala’s eyes. Cala gives no visible reaction for several seconds. It feels like hours have passed.

“You are not,” Cala says quietly.

“I am,” Dice says more forcefully.

“No, you—”

“Cala,” Maya interjects, giving her sister a hard look. “No interruptions.”

Cala’s face contorts with a moment of what looks like anger before regaining control and crossing her arms. She sits straighter and stares at Dice with barely restrained irritation.

“I have an apartment. I have steady employment and income. I am entering my graduate program for biochemistry.” Dice says firmly, her body turning to fully face Cala, hands firmly gripping her pants to prevent them from moving. Hand gestures only irritate her mother, and she does not want to push this further than she already has.

Upon hearing the list of things that are happening, particularly what Dice is studying, Cala’s fingers dig into her own biceps, her head tilting down and eyes narrowing at her child.

“That is not what we discussed.” The words come out through gritted teeth.

“No, it’s not. It’s what I want, Mom. I’m 22. I’ve done exactly what you’ve wanted my entire life up to now. I am allowed to be a person outside of you.”

The silence that follows is long and tense. Mother and child have a staring contest, Dice tilting her head up and straightening her posture a bit, trying to exude confidence and certainty, even though she would like to vomit.

Maya's eyes flick between the two, ready to intervene at a moment's notice. Cala has never been a physical disciplinarian, but this is wildly different from anything she has faced as a mother before. Dice has never been one to disobey, especially as Cala becomes more overbearing.

"You are making a mistake," Cala practically growls.

"Then it is a mistake I will happily make. I'm not a child anymore, Mom. I'm an adult, even if you still treat me like I'm still that 10-year-old fresh out of the hospital."

Cala freezes entirely. They never directly mention the accident. They never directly discuss what Cala still subconsciously blames herself for. It was simply never on the table. Dice may discuss it with Maya, but never with or in front of Cala.

"You are still my child—"

"Yes, but I am not a child," Dice interjects. "I am going into my graduate program. I will get my doctorate one day. But I will do it on my terms, with the degree that I want, and I will get the job that I want."

Tension builds visibly in Cala, her head raising, face twisting, eyes narrowing, until she releases a huff and gives a sharp nod. "Fine then. If you are an adult, then begone. Now."

Maya and Dice freeze, both staring at Cala. Maya speaks first, recovering quickly to lean towards her sister. "Cala, don't—"

“No.” Cala swiftly rises to her feet. “If Dice is an adult and does not need me, then she is not my dependent to manage. Thus, she is a tenant not paying rent in my house and must leave with her things immediately.”

“Cala, she can’t move in until—”

“Perhaps,” Cala raises her voice, looking at both down the length of her nose, “you both should have thought about that.”

Silence reigns. Dice stares at Cala with wide eyes. She sits in the dining room chair, feeling her world tilt around her. She knows Cala won’t respond well, but this is beyond what she expects. She assumes she will have to pry herself from her mother’s clutches, not have to scramble to gather her things, and get out.

Her aunt and mother continue to argue, but Dice can barely hear it over her deep, intense anxiety. The pressure release of it being over, alongside the fierce dismissal from a woman who has coiled herself around her broken body for over a decade, is too much.

She gets up in a daze, not noticing either woman quieting, as she walks, mechanically, to her room. The door slides open, and she steps in, looking around her childhood bedroom, but not really seeing any of it. This has been her home her entire life. She wants out, but not like this. She just wants a little freedom, but a complete cut off? What will she lose next? Does it even matter? This is the worst possible outcome. Even Cala physically lashing out would have been more manageable.

She slowly reaches for her most necessary belongings: her school and work screen, her maintenance tools, her hairbrush, teeth cleaner, and, most importantly, the picture of Cala, Maya, and her from when Maya had taken all three of them out for Dice’s 9th birthday. She still remembers that night. They had gone to a play, then dinner. Over burgers, which Cala typically

refuses, her aunt told a funny story about one of her students that made Dice giggly. That is one of the few times Dice remembers hearing her mother laugh, genuinely, openly, at anything.

“Dice?” Maya’s voice cuts through her spiraling. Dice jumps, then turns to see Maya in the doorway, her face deepening into empathetic pain. “Oh, Di,” she murmurs, stepping in and reaching for her face. Maya brushes tears that Dice hasn’t even noticed from her left eye. “I know, honey. Come on, let’s get your things and go. You can stay at my place, and I’ll call some friends to help me move your stuff. You just focus on breathing right now, okay?”

Dice can only nod mutely, leaning into Maya’s hand.

Maya gently guides Dice out, but she barely registers getting out the door, waiting at the Line stop, or getting back into Maya’s apartment. She only remembers waking up on Maya’s plush couch, the smell of coffee, and her aunt talking to someone over a voice link.

The next few days are a blur of crying, sleeping, and barely managing to scarf down a sandwich or a bowl of soup Maya brings Dice. The couch is her home until she can move in at the end of the week. If Dice were more aware, she would have been thankful that classes were over for the semester.

Finally, by the end of the day on Friday, nearly six days after the confrontation with her mother, Dice sits alone in her new room, surrounded by a meager four boxes of belongings to go through and put away.

Maya and her friends have gathered everything from the penthouse that is hers, brought it all to her new apartment, and even brought her some meals and cutlery until she can truly get her bearings. She still needs furniture for the rest of the main space, but as she sits on the floor, pulling out items and organizing while slowly eating some simple vegetable soup, she doesn’t

care about the rest of the apartment. She only cares about trying to find some solace in the place that feels like it has broken her relationship with her mother irreparably.

*You're An Adult, Now Act Like One*

The hotel room hummed in sympathy as Audrina stepped through the door and immediately collapsed onto the auto-adjusting bed. They groaned loudly in frustration, pressing their face into the pillow. Another failed roommate interview. They brushed their long auburn hair from their face and glanced at their achievement jewelry, gifts from their fathers that suddenly felt heavy. The bed's comfort settings were probably worth more than some people's monthly income, a fact that was starting to sink into their skin with uncomfortable clarity.

They pulled up their holo-display, scanning the dwindling list of potential roommates. Two days left before their fathers' support ran out, and they had already burned through almost two thousand credits, which covered their hotel stay and most of their food. They winced, remembering the "stress-relief" shopping they had done. Old habits die hard.

Their mind drifted back to that dinner nearly two weeks ago, the memory as crisp as the prestigious restaurant's table linens.



Audrina spotted their fathers at the entrance of Maison Azure, one of the city's few remaining traditional restaurants. They adjusted their flowing pastel dress, carefully selected from their extensive wardrobe, and touched the nose piercing they had received last month. Of course, the manager recognized them regularly. The Piro family are regulars.

"Papa! Father!" they called out, their naturally high-pitched voices carrying across the hushed dining room. Both men rose to greet them: Amies, tall and commanding in his perfectly tailored suit, his success in the tech industry evident in the subtle neural augmentation glinting at his temple, and Rone, shorter but no less elegant, his warm smile a perfect counterpoint to his husband's more reserved demeanor.

The usual cheek kisses were exchanged, but something felt off. There was a tension in Amies' shoulders that his Italian charm couldn't quite mask, and Rone's gentle eyes held a hint of worry.

"This is certainly unexpected," Audrina said, settling into their chair with a tense and forced smile. "Usually, our dinners are more scheduled affairs." They tried for a light tone, but their fathers exchanged that look, the one that always preceded uncomfortable conversations.

The server approached, their hospitality implant giving their eyes a subtle golden sheen. "Good evening, sirs and Ms. Audrina. The usual Pinot Grigio?"

"Please," Amies nodded, his attention elsewhere.

Once the server glided away, Rone reached across the table, taking Audrina's hand. His signet ring from the finance industry was warm against their skin. "Sweetheart, your father and I have been talking."

Audrina's stomach dropped. They knew that tone. This wasn't going to be a conversation they would enjoy.

"You're twenty-two," Amies said, his Italian accent becoming more pronounced as it always did during serious discussions. "You have a degree in interior design. You have talent. And you're still living in your childhood room, spending your days redecorating it for the seventh time this year."

"What your father means," Rone interrupts, shooting his husband a look, "is that we think it's time for you to spread your wings."

Audrina blinks. They open their mouths to argue, question, disagree, or say anything else, but their father beats them to the punch.

"We're cutting you off," Amies said bluntly, earning another look from Rone.

“Not completely,” Rone reassured, squeezing their hand gently.

Amies sighs and pinches the bridge of his nose. The men never fully agreed with their husbands’ opposing approaches to raising their children. “We’re giving you twenty thousand credits and two weeks to find your place in a hotel.”

Audrina’s jaw dropped. “Twenty thousand? That’s nothing! That’s, like, two designer outfits!” They stammered out, trying to pull their hand from their Papa’s.

“Exactly,” Rone said gently, holding their hand tighter so they couldn’t pull away before they finished talking. “Dearest, we have failed to properly instill the value of money and what we have given you over the years. The real value.” He sighs.

“This is absurd!” Audrina’s voice climbed higher. “How am I supposed to-?”

“You have a degree,” Amies interrupted, his face stony and voice barely hinting at his exasperation. “You have skills. The design firms are always looking for fresh talent, especially with the growing demand for accessible spaces.” He paused, his expression softening slightly. “The world *needs* what you can offer, Piccola. But you’ll never discover that from within your comfort zone.”

~~~~~

Audrina pulled up the last contact on their list in the hotel room. Dice Calen. The profile was sparse, just a room for rent in a ground-floor apartment, a reasonable rate, utilities included. The location made them wince. It was in one of those “transitional” neighborhoods that their fathers always steered clear of. But they had no options and no time.

The comm connection cracked and popped as it connected, probably old tech. Audrina couldn’t imagine. A low, slightly rough voice answered, “Hello?”

“Hi!” Audrina injected their voice with as much cheer as they could muster. “Is this Dice Calen? I saw your listing for a roommate.”

“Yeah,” the voice replied, a hint of surprise evident. “You’re the first to call.”

They arranged to meet the next day. As Audrina ended the call, they noticed their reflection in the window: designer clothes, multiple piercings, perfectly styled hair. They felt they were the ones to enter a different world than the one they had grown up in. That could be precisely what they needed.



Audrina smoothed their carefully selected pastel dress, checking their ear piercings and nose stud in the pod’s reflective surface before heading to the worn, metal entrance. The temperature controls hadn’t kicked in yet, making the metal uncomfortably warm around them. Their excitement at finding a potential place dimmed slightly as they took in the building’s exterior. The tan, L-shaped complex with its rusting railings was a far cry from their fathers’ penthouse in the upper sectors.

They found apartment 8 and knocked, unconsciously playing with the achievement necklace Amies had given them for graduating from design school. After what felt like forever, the door opened to reveal a short woman with striking features: deep blue eyes, black shoulder-length hair with a bold blue stripe, and warm, honey-colored skin. But what caught Audrina’s attention was the woman’s right arm. The synthetic skin was visibly deteriorating, with peeling at the joints, revealing glimpses of cybernetic components beneath.

“Audrina? Aren’t you early?” the woman whose name they had memorized, Dice, asked through a barely suppressed yawn, their voice raspier than it had been over the comm.

“What can I say? I was excited!” Audrina chirped, trying to bury their nerves and desperation under extra enthusiasm.

Dice stepped aside with a resigned gesture, seeming unsure how to handle their bright demeanor. “Well, uh, come in.”

Upon entering, Audrina’s designer instincts kicked in immediately. The space was practically begging for intervention. A fold-up table with mismatched chairs, a couch that had seen better decades, and walls crying out for color and life. Their fingers itched to pull out their tablet, already mentally sketching possibilities.

They moved down a short hallway to what would be their room. The space was small. They were sure their home closet was bigger, but their mind were already racing with ways to maximize it. “Oh yeah, I can *definitely* work with this,” they said, waving their hand more confidently than they felt. Their parents would probably be horrified if they saw where their princess was considering living.

Dice blinks but nods. “Okay, then,” they say slowly. Let’s head down to the office and get you on the lease.”

The paperwork was straightforward enough, though Audrina had to stop themselves from reflexively reaching for their fathers’ accounts when it came time for the deposit. Twenty thousand credits always seemed so small to them, but after nearly two weeks of trying to continue living to their usual standard, they barely had enough to get started here.

“I’ll be at work until around seven,” Dice mentioned as Audrina prepared to leave. “But you can start moving in whenever.”

Back in AutoLyft, Audrina pulled up their design software, fingers flying as they started planning. This bland apartment was an opportunity in disguise, a chance to prove they could

create beauty anywhere, even on a budget. For the first time since their father's ultimatum, they felt a deep excitement.

‘First priority: replacing that couch,’ they thought, already comparing affordable options. ‘Second priority: getting to know my new roomie!’ Their mind raced with possibilities for adaptive design elements that could work for both cyborg and non-cyborg residents. Living with a cyborg is new and exciting! Maybe this whole “being an adult” thing wouldn’t be so impossible after all. However, they would have to talk to their new roomie about that lighting. And those chairs. And... well, everything!

Up & Out

Duman stared out over the ledge of Mount Kesta, his exposed cybernetic arm glinting in the late afternoon sun. It took several blissful hours to reach this point, but documenting the hike with his antique Caruno camera was the most fulfilling part. The repetitive and purposeful movements allowed him to avoid thoughts of his latest job rejection. Here, above the city's oppressive layers of "development," "improvement," and "growth" that the world leaders spouted, he could almost forget about the medical bills crushing his family, the constant struggle to find employers who would look past his exposed cybernetics, and the uncertainty of where he'd live next. On top of a mountain, surrounded by nature that most had forgotten about and taken for granted in the sleek and modern world, he was free. Duman could finally breathe.

The metal of his artificial hand scraped against the thin screen as he pulled it from his pocket. He turned the nearly transparent device back on, blinking rapidly as it received several messages, calls, and other notifications after being offline for most of the day. He grimaced at all the clear attempts his Pops had made to get a hold of him. Duman knew he would have hell to pay once he finally answered, but another notification caught his eye. Someone had finally responded to his post about needing a place to stay. He stared at the notification for a brief moment before tucking the device away. 'Later,' he thought, reaching for his camera instead.

The backpack caught on his arm's exposed components again, making him huff in frustration. He'd never bothered with synthetic skin. His family was already swimming in debt. He never cared how anyone saw him, saw his arm. Not using synthetic skin gave him easier maintenance access, saving money. As long as he isn't foolish, like his Pops always says, his arm shouldn't need more than typical maintenance. Once he finally freed himself, he turned back to the view, camera in hand. "This ought to make Momma feel better," he murmured,

raising the ancient Caruno 2124 to his eyes. It was the last gift his parents had been able to afford before his mother's illness began draining their savings and plucking their paychecks before all else. Looking back, his 13th birthday was one of the last that felt genuinely happy. It was a miracle that it had worked when his parents had found it. Duman had put so much time, money, and effort into fixing and maintaining it. He had always been mechanically gifted. He never would have imagined those skills being put to use on his own arm.

Duman took several shots, carefully adjusting the manual settings between each one. The light breeze made him sigh and shiver. It was hard to find a place in the major sectors. He can remember his grandmother talking about the breeze over the fields of the farming sectors, the smell of rain, and old trees. He settled into the moment, listening to the sound of the world without pods, tycoons, or endless machinery. For just a moment, he felt at peace. Another buzz in his back pocket. He frowned, closed his eyes, and took a deep breath as he turned the phone off again. It was time to rejoin the rest of the "civilized" world.



The trip down took significantly less time, a mere two and a half hours compared to his earlier four, nearly five. He might have taken more time without the motivation to call his Pops back, but with his Momma in the hospital, he needed that stable connection at the base of the mountain. Duman collapsed with a long sigh into his beat-up Chalo pod, exhausted but content. As he checked his messages, the vehicle's engine hummed to life with its characteristic wheeze. There had only been 38 calls at the summit. The number has since grown to a mere 47. The messages, well, he didn't see the word 'dead,' so he simply pulled up his Pops and called back with a deep breath. This was going to be one hell of a talk.

“Duman! Where the *hell* have you been? Do you have *any idea*-?” Clayton Turna was already on a tirade, which thinly hid his concern for his boy. If something were genuinely wrong, especially with Adelaide, *his* Addie, Duman wouldn’t have any opportunity to interrupt.

“Pops, breathe,” Duman cut him off, recognizing the spiral of worried anger.

“Breathe?! Where do you-?”

“*Pops*.”

Clayton grumbled but followed Duman’s lead. They took some deep breaths, calmed down together, and finally, Clayton’s deep-set Southern accent flowed through the connection more coherently. “Dune, you crazy boy. Yer alrigh’? Where are ya?”

“I’m fine. I’ll be home in a few hours. How’s Momma?”

“As good as she can be. She’ll probably feel a hell of a lot better when you get yer ass home.” A pause, a huff. “Heard anythin’ about a new place?”

“Someone replied,” Duman said, nodding unconsciously despite the lack of a video link.

“Well, does someone have a name?”

Duman hesitated, trying to recall the details he’d only glanced at. “Er, Dice something... I think.”

Duman could hear the exasperation and tempered hope in his old man’s sigh. “Better than nothin’.” Another pause. “Well, you hurry home. Yer Momma’s worried sick.”

Guilt clawed at Duman’s chest. He knew running to the mountain had been selfish, purely for his own relief. He hadn’t meant to worry his parents, yet he had. “I’ll do my best. See you soon.”

“Ya better. Love ya, Dune.”

“Love you too, Pops.”

Duman sat in silence as the link closed. He stared straight ahead, letting the conversation, his actions, and their consequences settle on his shoulders. He could hear his Momma's wisdom:

"Intent can make some things understandable. But that doesn't change how the actions or words affect people from the get-go. So think before you do."

He can still see her smile, hear her soft laugh, and feel her boop his nose. They were simpler days, easier nights, and no constant hospital visits.

Duman sighed and pulled up the response to his post, pushing the memory aside for the moment. Dice Calen. That was the name. The message was simple: "My roommate and I are looking for another roommate to help pay bills. If you want to check on the apartment, you can reach me at my cell number."

"How bad could it be?" Duman mumbled, pressing the number and initiating the link.

"Hello?" A low, rough voice answered.

"Hi, is this Dice Calen?" Duman ran his flesh fingers over the old camera in his lap as he spoke, hoping it could give him the confidence he had out on the trail.

"This is she. Who is this?"

"I'm Duman Turna. You said I could call to check out your place."

"Oh, right." She sounded surprised. "Well, I'm glad you reached out. It's been pretty hard to get someone to come around. Is there any particular time you want to go by?"

It was already six in the evening. Between his hike and the late hospital visiting hours, there was no way he'd make it today. "I'm free anytime tomorrow." He finally offered.

"How does noon sound?"

"Works for me."

“Alright, I’ll text you the address.”

“Cool. Uh, see ya tomorrow?” Uncertainty crept into his voice despite his best efforts.

“See you tomorrow,” she replied confidently, then ended the link.

Duman sighed heavily, sagging into the seat for just a moment. Then, he pulled back up and pulled up the Nav Center, heading home with just enough time to shower before visiting hours ended for the day. Nearly 45 minutes later, he was rushing through his bowl of cereal, then back into the temperamental vomit yellow pod. He made it to the hospital with barely fifteen minutes to spare.

“Can I still go see my mother? Please?” he asked the front desk attendant, not bothering to hide his desperation.

She glanced at the clock and then at him with a resigned sigh. “Yeah. Just make it quick.”

Duman nodded quickly, gratefully, and hustled to the elevator. His mother’s room was exactly as it had been yesterday and the day before. Her simple being made the antiseptic white walls slightly more bearable. “Duman.” Her voice was raspy but soft and relieved, that familiar slow Southern accent that had always meant home and safety, no matter how strained, even now.

“Hey, Momma.” He smiled softly. Seeing her was a comfort he hadn’t taken for granted in years. She looked so small and frail in the hospital bed. Without Adelaide’s striking amber eyes and the birthmark on her cheek, she would look nothing like the strong woman who’d raised him.

“You’re okay.” The warm relief in her voice made guilt twist in his stomach.

“Yeah, Momma. I’m fine. How are you?” He regretted the question as she started to laugh, but broke into a coughing fit instead. Duman jumped to her side, his face and eyes drenched in worry. She was getting worse.

Adelaide waved him off and took a deep breath. “As good as I can be. Especially now that you’re here.” She patted his cheek with a hand that seemed frailer every visit, smiling warmly in a way he wasn’t convinced he deserved right now. Duman leaned into her touch before carefully pulling out his camera.

“Got some good shots today. Wanna see?” He could only grin when she lit up, patting the bed and making space for him to settle beside her. They escaped into his photographs for several minutes, her eyes brightening at each new image. Duman had always heard jokes, even joined in occasionally, that Adelaide never needed optical enhancements, given how bright and lively her eyes naturally were. When they reached the last photo, he took a breath, leaning lightly on her shoulder, and quietly said, “Found a place with some free space. Gonna check it out tomorrow.”

“Really? Oh, that’s great to hear. I’m so proud of you, Dune.” Though weaker than it used to be, her smile still transformed her entire face.

A nurse appeared in the doorway. “Excuse me, I’m sorry, but visiting hours are over.” Her expression was sympathetic but firm. Duman hugged Adelaide as if she were made of glass, trying not to think about how real that felt. She kissed his temple and managed a small wave as he left.

He found his father sitting at the dining table at home, lost in thought. “ey, Pops,” Duman called quietly, tugging off his boots at the door before sitting beside him. Clayton looked

at him with an expression he couldn't quite read. Not an exceptionally uncommon occurrence for the older man.

"You remember the smile Momma would get on her face on Mother's Day? When we'd wake her up with breakfast, a gift, or somethin'?" Duman asked softly, the memory surfacing uninvited but not unwelcome.

A small smile spread across Clayton's face. "Yeah, I 'member. Though nothing will beat her smile when she told me we were havin' you. That was the biggest grin I've ever seen, even on 'er."

His father looked him in the eyes and scooted his chair closer. Duman could imagine that giant, lopsided grin. Maybe from one of her jokes or terrible puns. He matched Clayton's movement, moving his chair closer and pulling his father into a tight hug. They squeezed each other like the embrace could squash every problem through sheer force.

"She smiled when I showed her my pictures and told her about that apartment," Duman mumbled against Clayton's shoulder. "I'm gonna meet that lady tomorrow."

Clayton nodded, then pulled back just enough to look at him. "You know we love ya, right?"

"I love you guys, too," Duman replied softly. They sat there, holding each other for a while longer, neither too worried about letting go anytime soon.

~~~~

Duman's body finally claimed payment for the previous day's emotional and physical drain as he overslept by half an hour. By the time he finally found the right apartment complex, he was nearly an hour late. He quickly found apartment eight, noting the worn metal doors and peeling paint. The building was still better maintained than others he'd seen around the sect.

A short woman with deep blue eyes, black shoulder-length hair holding a stripe of blue down the left side, and warm, honey-colored skin answered his knock. But what caught his attention immediately was her right arm. The synthetic skin differed from her natural tones, was considerably paler, lacked the life that skin usually has, and was peeling at the joints. The cybernetic components peeked through in weak spots, achingly familiar to someone who'd stopped bothering with synthetic covering altogether, or been forced to, by whatever life had thrown around.

"Take it you're Duman?" Her low, rough voice matched her direct gaze.

"Hey. Dice, right?" He offered his left hand automatically, momentarily hesitating in a way only cyborgs do.

"Yeah." She shook his hand without hesitation, neither surprised nor bothered by the metal. "Um, you wanna come in?" She offered, stepping back to let him in.

"Sure. Hey, um, I'm sorry I'm late. I overslept and..." His apology died as he stepped inside. The interior was nothing like the building's exterior suggested. It was like walking into a desert oasis. Warm tans blend with shades of blues and greens, with touches of purple and pink adding depth. Flowers and trees seemed to grow from the walls, creating an illusion of natural space in the cramped apartment.

"Like it?" Dice asked, stepping beside him to admire the work with a half smile. "All my roommate's doing. Audrina's an interior designer. Really fixed up the place." She snickers at an untold joke.

Duman blinks but quickly smiles. "I can tell. Looks like they've got talent."

"Better believe it. They're at work right now." Dice breathes and leans on her left side a little more. "Audrina doesn't really care who I let move in."

“They don’t?” The casual trust surprised him, especially given his visible cybernetics. Even other cyborgs didn’t always trust his lack of conformity.

Dice shrugs. “Audrina’s pretty carefree. Dangerously so,” she said with a hint of fondness and exasperation. “They said they trust me to pick someone good. Safe.”

“Should I be worried?” He managed a half-smile, only half joking.

“Nah, they’re harmless. Let me show you around.” Dice waved off his concern, her cybernetic arm catching the light. Unlike his exposed components, her synthetic skin still attempted to maintain the illusion of normalcy, however imperfectly.

The tour didn’t take long. The apartment was modest but thoughtfully laid out. Before he knew it, they were at the building’s office, his name being added to the lease. As he signed, a strange feeling settled in his chest, something between relief and anticipation.

“Come pick me up tomorrow, and I’ll help you move,” Dice offered as they wrapped up.

Duman nodded, already thinking about how he’d tell his parents. His mother’s smile flashed in his mind, and he found himself grinning as he returned to his pod. Things were finally looking up.